

Hello all SILS Students!

We have entered the last full month of the semester! It's bananas how fast this school year went by. In this newsletter, you'll see updates about the ILSSA leadership election, opportunities to chat with Dean Kelly, cover letter/ CV review opportunities, and a course update from Dr. Shaw.

SILS Updates:

From Interim Dean Dr. Diane Kelly:

Coffee and Conversation!

Drop in for coffee, bagels, and casual conversation with Dean Kelly.

April 7: 8:30 - 9:30am

May 6: 9 - 10am

You're invited - SILS and SDSS faculty will be sharing their research this month!

Join the School of Information and Library Science (SILS) and the School of Data Science and Society (SDSS) for the next [INSPIRE Research Symposium](#) on **Wednesday, April 15, from 3–4:30 p.m.** in the Pleasants Room at Wilson Library.

The symposium will feature a series of fast-paced, 10-minute research talks from nine faculty members from SILS and SDSS, showcasing a wide range of innovative and interdisciplinary research topics.

This event is open to the SILS and SDSS community. Come learn about the exciting work happening across both schools!

INSPIRE Research Symposium - School of Information and Library Science

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ILSSA Updates:

Thank you to all who came to the admitted students event at TOPO and our spring field day picnic! It was delightful to spend time outside with y'all.

Shoutout to everyone who decorated cakes for the book decorating event last week! If you would like your dessert to be featured on our Instagram (@sils_ilssagram), please email ilssa@unc.edu the photo!

Election results are being communicated to the nominees. Once I have received all acceptances from the winners, I will send out an announcement of the new leadership team.

LAUNC-CH Spring 2026 Resume/CL Review (and potential mock interviews)

This spring, the LAUNC-CH Professional Development Committee will again be hosting our popular cover letter & resume review service on an asynchronous, rolling basis for students in the SILS program and LAUNCCH members. Our goal is to provide helpful feedback and insights on job application materials as many information and library science students begin their job searches prior to spring graduation.

<https://forms.office.com/r/vLJrPBdaKV>

Please fill out this form

From Dr. Ryan Shaw:

Fall 2026 Course: INLS 620 Distributed Knowledge Graphs 1

Note: Due to a series of bureaucratic errors, this course is listed **incorrectly** in the course catalog as INLS 620 Web Information Organization. The correct course name and description is above.

Knowledge graphs are interlinked descriptions of things—objects, people, products, events, concepts—and the relations among them. Distributed knowledge graphs are published on the Web and maintained collaboratively. This course covers the core concepts and standards needed to understand and work effectively with distributed knowledge graphs, including the Resource Description Framework (RDF), the SPARQL Protocol and RDF Query Language (SPARQL), and the Web Ontology Language (OWL).

Why learn about knowledge graphs?

Archives and cultural heritage

Knowledge graph-based archival standards like [Records in Contexts \(RiC\)](#) replace the fixed, tree-structured descriptive frameworks that have long constrained cultural heritage metadata with a flexible graph model that can accommodate multiple, overlapping, and even contradictory perspectives—including indigenous knowledge systems that institutional description has historically suppressed or ignored.

Health informatics

Biomedical knowledge graphs like the NCBI's PubChem, the [Monarch Initiative's](#) Phenotype Knowledge Graph, and industry platforms such as AstraZeneca's BioKG integrate heterogeneous data across genes, diseases, drugs, and phenotypes to power drug repurposing, adverse event prediction, and precision medicine by enabling traversal of mechanistic pathways that siloed relational databases cannot express.

Business and finance

Knowledge graphs underpin enterprise data integration and financial intelligence platforms, powering applications from supply chain risk monitoring to anti-money laundering detection by representing entities like companies, transactions, and beneficial owners as nodes in a web of relationships that exposes patterns of fraud, conflict of interest, and systemic exposure that tabular data and conventional queries routinely miss.

AI agents

Knowledge graphs are increasingly serving as the structured, updateable memory and world-model layer for AI agents, giving them a semantically grounded representation of entities, relationships, and

constraints that complements the statistical associations embedded in large language models and enables more reliable multi-step reasoning, tool selection, and action planning in agentic pipelines.

Can undergrads take it?

Yes! In past semesters, the class has been evenly split between undergraduate students and graduate students, and undergraduates have done very well.

What are the prerequisites?

Either INLS 560 or INLS 520 is recommended, but both are waivable. Contact Ryan Shaw at ryanshaw@unc.edu if you have questions.

Is there a Distributed Knowledge Graphs 2?

Yes! In Spring 2027, I will teach Distributed Knowledge Graphs 2: Construction and Maintenance. This is a practice-based course in which we will build and maintain a knowledge graph for an external “client.” Students will get hands-on experience working with real data and building reliable processes for enriching, interlinking, and publishing it on the Web.

Cheers,
ILSSA Executive Board

Submit to the next newsletter:
> <https://forms.gle/iFH2x9EcX7hiYy7c9> <

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